

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

The event that heralded the beginning of global competition for India's largest-ever defence contract was held at a remarkably prosaic venue: the protocol room in the reception area of Air Headquarters in Delhi. On a warm Tuesday afternoon on August 28, over coffee and biscuits, an air vice-marshal handed out bulky sealed envelopes to a gathering of five people representing some of the world's largest military firms. In each envelope were 211 pages of a Request for Proposals (RFP) detailing the Indian Air Force's (IAF's) requirement for 126 Medium Multi-Role Combat Aircraft (MMRCA) worth an estimated \$10 billion (Rs 40,000 crore). This is India's first-ever global tender for fighter aircraft.

"MMRCA are the air force's most critical requirement. We are retiring aircraft fast. The authorised strength is 39.5 squadrons (each squadron has 18 aircraft) but we haven't had that strength for six years," says former Air Chief Marshal S. Krishnaswamy. This is a result of the rapid phase-out of the MiG-21—the workhorse that makes up nearly 40 per cent of the IAF fleet—with no replacement in sight. The indigenous Light Combat Aircraft (LCA) Tejas, meant to replace the MiG, is still under trial and at least five years away from induction. In the next eight years, after having retired all but 100 of its vintage MiG-21s, IAF will be left with just 26 squadrons, the projected size of the Pakistan Air Force (PAF). IAF, which aspires to be the ultimate in aero-space protection, could not have ignored this serious shortfall.

The balance of air power in South Asia is already turning against India, with China and Pakistan pumping billions into modernising their air forces. In the next decade, PAF will acquire over

THE MOTHER OF ALL DEALS

With its squadron strength sagging, India throws open a Rs 40,000-crore global contest to acquire 126 fighter aircraft

200 new fighter aircraft, including the JF-17 jointly developed with China and the F-16 Block 50 from the US, ensuring near-parity with IAF. With China planning to induct nearly 600 sophisticated fighters including the Su-30 over the next decade, IAF should re-evaluate its decision of deploying older aircraft on its eastern frontiers.

Armed with an array of long-range missiles and smart munitions, the medium-range combat aircraft that IAF plans to acquire will not only replace the MiG-21, but also give it an edge in fighter aircraft. IAF gets to choose from among six suitors—the F/A-18 Super Hornet, the F-16, the Rafale, the Gripen, the MiG-35 and the Eurofighter Typhoon. This lethal platform can switch from shooting down enemy fighters to killing warships and vaporising tanks and bunkers at the flick of a switch, before the enemy can even spot them. But first, the aircraft will have to pass through extensive flight trials followed by commercial bids, after which the Government will open negotiations with the short-

listed manufacturer. The process will be tedious and the contract is likely to be signed only after three years.

It will take at least 10 years for all seven MMRCA squadrons to be inducted into the air force, giving it a massive shot of adrenaline. IAF, which wants the aircraft to be capable of upgradation, intends to use them for a period of 40 years. While the manufacturer will deliver the first 18 aircraft within four years of signing the contract, the remaining 108 aircraft will be licence-built in India by Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL), with massive infusions of technology into the country's nascent aerospace industry. It is for this reason that analysts are

